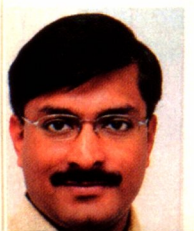




MILKY WAY: Everyday necessities are going low-cal

about 75 per cent of the marketshare." Zydus Cadila Healthcare, which is working on brand extensions, recently introduced Sugar Free D'Lite, a low-calorie fruity drink which is available both as a powder concentrate and in ready-to-drink form. Available in five non-cola flavours—orange, peach, lemon, apple and passion fruit—it is 99 per cent calorie-free and is fortified with electrolytes.

It's easy to understand why the diet food and drink segment is growing fast. While a teaspoon of sugar has 240 calories, a pellet of any sugar substitute has zero to two calories. Capitalising on the growing trend and increased consumer interest, Amul has come up with its Sugarfree Probiotic Frozen Dessert, which is not only low in calories, but also contains a bacterial culture that aids in digestion and improves immunity. From Mother Dairy's low-fat ice creams to Nestle's Kit Kat Lite and Maggi's Healthy Soups, no company wants to be left behind.



"The share of diet products will go up by 10 per cent in three years." PAUL THACIL, CEO, MOTHER DAIRY

"For the consumer's benefit, we mention the presence of certain ingredients." ARUN HEGDE, CEO, WRIGLEY INDIA



Apart from the diet market for indulgences such as ice cream and chocolate, that for everyday necessities like milk and dairy products is also growing. They are now increasingly being sold in toned and skimmed form. Of the Rs 20,000-crore branded milk market, the low-fat category accounts for Rs 2,200 crore. If Mother Dairy has introduced probiotic dahi, Nestle has a number of diet products on offer, including Slim Milk and Everyday Slim, a low-calorie dairy whitener. Says Paul Thacil, CEO, Mother Dairy: "We expect the share of diet products to go up by 10 per cent in three years. Our R&D is focusing on bringing diet products as close as possible in taste to regular products."

But what is the downside to the diet story? The answer lies in the ingredients which make these products low-cal. Most low-calorie foods and beverages essentially use sugar substitutes and sweeteners like fructo-oligo-saccharides. Amul uses these saccharides in its frozen desserts. Says Sodhi: "Digestive enzymes sparingly digest these

sweeteners in the stomach or small intestines. So there is no fluctuation in blood sugar levels, whereas intake of digestible sugar causes fluctuation in the blood sugar level."

While research has thrown up better alternatives to sugar, the most common one that companies use is aspartame. It is sold under several brand

names, has a complex chemical structure, and is highly controversial due to reports of certain side effects. One part of its structure is methanol, commonly known as wood alcohol. When consumed as part of the aspartame chemical, it is broken down by the small intestine into formaldehyde, which is a strong preservative.

Most companies which use aspartame vouch for the safety of their products.

While stating that their products are absolutely safe, Arun Hegde, CEO of Wrigley India, says: "A very small percentage of the population—one in 15,000—has a rare, inherited disease known as Phenylketonuria, which prevents their body from properly handling phenylalanine. People with this condition must consider aspartame as an additional source of phenylalanine. Complying with regulations, all aspartame-containing foods must carry a statement mentioning the presence of the ingredient."

It is therefore important for consumers to know the ingredients before jumping onto the low-cal bandwagon. For instance, some

products may claim to be diet-friendly, but may not actually be low in calories. UB Group launched McDowell's No. 1 Diet Mate whisky and Romanov Diet Vodka last year. While the label may say diet, the drinks merely contain the herb Garcinia (*kokum*), which increases the rate of metabolism. Sales of UB's Diet Mate whisky have touched 25 per cent of the total sales of the mother brand, which sells a record six million cases a year. Marketers may be raking in moolah by selling indulgences sans the guilt of calories, but don't forget to read the fineprint before joining the diet bogey.

